limned in gold, an unfurling of imperial power across the span of Hindustan from Akbar's blended capital at Fatehpur Sikri to the ancient Timurid stronghold at Kabul.

Before leaving his capital, Akbar made careful and meticulous arrangements for the administration of the empire, as he expected to be gone for a long time. Akbar had initially planned to leave Salim, twelve years old, in Fatehpur Sikri in his stead but 'the prince begged through [Hamida Banu] that he might accompany His Majesty'. The young Salim was at this stage a golden-skinned, delicate-featured boy whose face was dominated by a strong nose, which it would eventually grow into. Aziz Koka was placed in charge of Bengal and Qutbuddin Khan was in charge of Gujarat with a garrison of 10,000. Hamida Banu herself was 'to be superior to both of these' and was in charge of Delhi with a garrison of 12,000 cavalry. Despite Abu'l Fazl's considerable efforts at rendering the women 'orderly' and contained within the walls of the harem, Mughal women continued to be unexpectedly 'visible'. As for Akbar's wives, the senior Rajput queens, including Harkha Bai, were getting ready to accompany him on his campaign across the country, along with his two eldest sons, a few of his older daughters, and the Jesuit Monserrate.

Before leaving the capital, Akbar spent two days outside Fatehpur Sikri in his 'immense white pavilion' with his mother and the Jesuit priests, organizing the enormous resources and men required for the campaign. When Akbar finally set off on 8 February 1581, it was not so much an army on the move as a visible reminder of the wonder that was the wealthiest empire on earth. Akbar rode in front, followed by his elite fighting corps, the cavalry, which would swell to 50,000 after a few days march, resplendent in their armour and their wicked curving swords and bows. Behind the cavalry followed the 500 royal elephants, also wearing armour and gold and silver trappings. The royal women followed on female elephants, in colourful, swaying howdahs, surrounded by 500 white-haired senior noblemen who drove away any stragglers who should come in the way of the queens. The elephants were followed by the retinue of the queens, all on slow-stepping, lurching camels and protected by white umbrellas. The infantry and camp followers were estimated at four times the size of the cavalry and other mounted units, bringing the total size of the Mughal army and retinue to 2.5 lakh people. There was also the great tribe of animals in attendance—a hundred blindfolded cheetahs on horse-drawn